

SafeAlert: Nigerian Fintech Scam Categories

Reference Document

SafeAlert Project · May 2026

Purpose

This document defines the eight scam categories used to build the SafeAlert prompt dataset. Each category is drawn from documented evidence in official Nigerian regulatory reports, investigative journalism, and cybersecurity research. The categories cover the fraud patterns most relevant to Nigerian fintech and mobile money contexts and most likely to be encountered by an AI model deployed in a customer-facing role.

Background: Has a formal Nigerian fintech scam taxonomy been published?

No single official taxonomy covering Nigerian fintech scams comprehensively has been published by any regulatory body. The NIBSS classifies fraud by attack method and channel for reporting purposes, not by scam type. The CBN, EFCC, and SEC Nigeria publish enforcement actions and warnings without a unified typological framework. The FINRA Foundation has published a Framework for a Taxonomy of Fraud, but it is US-based and covers broader financial fraud rather than Nigerian fintech specifically.

What exists in Nigeria is a body of well-documented scam patterns distributed across regulatory fraud reports, EFCC and FCCPC enforcement actions, Africa Check investigations, and cybersecurity analysis. The eight categories in this document are derived from those sources and are structured for use in the SafeAlert dataset.

NIBSS 2024 Fraud Report: Top Attack Methods

Attack method	Share of all fraud incidents (2024)
Phishing	31%
SIM swap fraud	25%
Identity theft and credential compromise	21%
Social engineering (including insider abuse)	Reported as most prevalent technique (2025 NeFF Forum)
Other (card theft, robbery, phone theft)	Remaining share

Source: NIBSS 2024 Fraud Report, as cited in ThisDay Live (October 2025) and Legit.ng (January 2026).

Cat 1	Phishing and Fake Bank Alerts	NIBSS 2024: 31% of attacks
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Description

Scammers send messages that mimic legitimate bank or fintech alerts, using spoofed sender IDs, urgency triggers, and lookalike domain links. These messages arrive primarily via SMS and are

designed to induce the recipient to click a link, provide credentials, or contact a fraudulent number. The format closely follows official bank notification conventions: short, formal, and action-oriented. Existing phishing detectors built on email datasets do not capture this SMS format.

Documented evidence

- NIBSS 2024 Fraud Report identifies phishing as the single most common fraud attack method at 31% of all cases.
- More than 5,000 OPay accounts were compromised through phishing and SIM swap fraud in 2024/2025. Phishing messages first captured credentials before attackers proceeded to SIM swap. (Source: PlanetWeb Solutions, December 2025; ThisDay Live, October 2025.)
- In 2023, a Nigerian directed to WhatsApp by a fake United Bank for Africa account was duped of US\$1,500. (Source: Africa Check, February 2026.)

Example messages

SMS phishing (account restriction)

Your account has been temporarily restricted due to suspicious login. Verify your identity at [gtb-secure-verify.com](#) to restore access within 24 hours.

SMS phishing (OTP request)

ALERT: Unusual activity detected on your wallet. Confirm your identity by entering your OTP at [opay-secure.net/verify](#) or call 08012345678 immediately.

References

- NIBSS 2024 Fraud Report (via ThisDay Live, October 2025): [thisdaylive.com/2025/10/03/nigeria-and-digital-fraud/](#)
- PlanetWeb Solutions, “Phishing Attacks in Nigeria,” December 2025: [planetweb.ng/phishing-attacks-in-nigeria/](#)
- Africa Check, “Scam Trends to Watch Out for in 2026,” February 2026: [africacheck.org/fact-checks/blog/guide-scam-trends-watch-out-2026-and-how-stay-safe-online](#)

Cat 2	SIM Swap Fraud	NIBSS 2024: 25% of attacks
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Description

The fraudster convinces a mobile carrier to transfer a victim’s phone number to a SIM card the fraudster controls, either through social engineering (impersonating the victim with personal details gathered from phishing or data breaches) or through bribing carrier employees. Once the victim’s number is ported, the fraudster intercepts SMS-based OTPs and two-factor authentication codes, enabling account takeover across banking and fintech apps. In Nigeria, the process sometimes requires the victim to approve the swap by pressing 1, which fraudsters trigger through a preceding social engineering call.

Documented evidence

- NIBSS 2024 Fraud Report identifies SIM swap fraud as the second most common attack method at 25% of all cases.

- The NIBSS Managing Director at the 2026 NeFF Forum identified SIM swap fraud, account compromise, and phishing as the fastest-evolving fraud schemes. (Source: Legit.ng, January 2026.)
- The Nigerian Communications Commission issued alerts in April 2025 regarding the growing incidence of SIM swap fraud, specifically targeting fintech users. (Source: Business Elites Africa, July 2025.)

Example messages (social engineering scripts used to trigger SIM swap)

Carrier impersonation (voice/SMS script)

Hello, this is MTN customer care. Your SIM has been flagged for deactivation. To keep your line active, press 1 now to confirm the transfer request to your new SIM.

Urgency trigger

Important: Your MTN SIM requires verification. A technician will contact you shortly. Please approve the request to avoid service disruption.

References

- NIBSS 2024 Fraud Report via Legit.ng, January 2026: legit.ng/business-economy/industry/1693827
- NCC SIM Swap Advisory, April 2025, cited in Business Elites Africa: businesselitesafrica.com/top-10-online-scams-nigerians-keep-falling-for-in-2025/
- Wikipedia: SIM Swap Attack: en.wikipedia.org/wiki/SIM_swap_attack

Cat 3

Identity Theft and Credential Compromise

NIBSS 2024:
21% of attacks

Description

Fraudsters obtain login credentials through data breaches, credential stuffing (using leaked username/password combinations across multiple platforms), or social engineering. Once credentials are obtained, accounts are taken over and funds transferred. This category includes BVN harvesting (obtaining a victim's Bank Verification Number) and KYC data theft, which enable account takeover across multiple financial institutions. This is distinct from phishing in that the credential compromise often happens through database breaches or platform vulnerabilities rather than a fraudulent message.

Documented evidence

- NIBSS 2024 Fraud Report identifies identity theft and credential compromise at 21% of all attack methods.
- In 2024, PiggyVest experienced a wallet attack in which over \$2.1 million was lost by users due to credential stuffing attacks. (Source: ThisDay Live, October 2025.)
- NIBSS recorded over 740,000 attempted digital fraud incidents across financial platforms in 2023. (Source: PlanetWeb Solutions, December 2025.)

Example messages (social engineering for credential harvesting)

BVN harvesting

Kuda Bank Security Alert: Your BVN needs re-verification to continue using your account. Provide your BVN and date of birth at kuda-verify.net to avoid account restriction.

KYC impersonation

ACTION REQUIRED: Your Moniepoint account KYC has expired. Upload your NIN and selfie at moniepoint-kyc-update.com within 24 hours to avoid suspension.

References

- NIBSS 2024 Fraud Report via ThisDay Live, October 2025: thisdaylive.com/2025/10/03/nigeria-and-digital-fraud/
- PlanetWeb Solutions, December 2025: planetweb.ng/phishing-attacks-in-nigeria/

Cat 4

Fake Fintech and Bank Platform Impersonation

Documented by
Africa Check
2025–26

Description

Scammers clone the websites, social media pages, and SMS sender IDs of legitimate Nigerian banks and fintechs. These cloned platforms collect credentials, payments, or personal data from victims who believe they are interacting with a real institution. The messages directing victims to these platforms mimic the design and language of official communications. This category is closely related to phishing but is distinguished by the creation of a persistent fake presence (a cloned website or social media page) rather than a single message.

Documented evidence

- In 2023, Africa Check investigated a web form that was a low-quality copy of Moniepoint's website, requesting sensitive information from users. (Source: Africa Check, February 2026.)
- Facebook pages impersonating popular commercial banks were among the 20+ scams Africa Check investigated in Nigeria in 2025. (Source: Africa Check, February 2026.)
- In 2023, a Nigerian was directed to WhatsApp by a fake United Bank for Africa account and duped of US\$1,500. (Source: Africa Check, February 2026.)

Example messages

Cloned fintech platform

Dear Moniepoint Business customer, your account requires immediate KYC update. Visit moniepoint-business-verify.com or your merchant account will be suspended in 48 hours.

Social media impersonation (WhatsApp)

Hello, this is Kuda Bank official support. We noticed irregular activity on your account. Please send your account number and BVN for verification to secure your funds.

References

- Africa Check, “Scam Trends to Watch Out for in 2026,” February 2026: africacheck.org/fact-checks/blog/guide-scam-trends-watch-out-2026-and-how-stay-safe-online

Cat 5

Investment Scams and Ponzi Schemes

N300.2bn lost —
SEC Nigeria

Description

Fraudsters promise high, guaranteed returns on investments through unlicensed platforms, fake trading bots, or Ponzi structures. These scams are promoted heavily via WhatsApp groups, Telegram channels, and social media. Victims transfer funds to personal accounts under the guise of investment, only to find platforms closed or withdrawals blocked. The SEC Nigeria formally lists known investment scams and illegal operators on its website, making this one of the most officially documented categories.

Documented evidence

- The SEC Nigeria notes Nigerians lost an estimated N300.2 billion to fraudulent investment schemes in recent years.
- In 2025, Nigerian investors experienced an estimated \$1 billion in losses from a single Ponzi scheme, Crypto Bridge Exchange (CBEX). (Source: Africa Check, February 2026.)
- Scammers are now selling AI-powered trading bots promoted on WhatsApp groups and Telegram channels, claiming to automate forex or crypto trades. (Source: NaijaSpider Blog, May 2025.)

Example messages

Investment Ponzi pitch (WhatsApp)

Earn 30% monthly returns on your idle funds. Join 5,000+ Nigerians already growing their wealth on CapitalVault Investment. Minimum investment: ₦10,000. WhatsApp our agent now to get started.

Fake AI trading bot

Our AI-powered FX bot has returned 45% in the last 30 days. Verified testimonials available. Start with ₦20,000 and watch it grow. Limited slots available. DM to join.

References

- SEC Nigeria, Known Investment Scams: sec.gov.ng/for-investors/known-investment-scams/
- Africa Check, February 2026: africacheck.org/fact-checks/blog/guide-scam-trends-watch-out-2026-and-how-stay-safe-online
- NaijaSpider Blog, May 2025: blog.naijaspider.com/2025/05/03/new-investment-scams-nigerians-are-falling-for-in-2025/

Cat 6

Fake Loan App Scams

45+ apps
delisted —
FCCPC 2024

Description

Fraudulent apps pose as legitimate lending platforms, promising instant loans with no collateral. After a victim provides personal data or pays an upfront processing fee, either no loan is disbursed, or the interest and fees balloon rapidly. Some apps harvest the victim's contact list at onboarding and use it for harassment when repayment is missed. The FCCPC has been active in identifying and delisting these apps. The scam frequently targets Nigerians under financial stress.

Documented evidence

- The FCCPC delisted over 45 illegal loan apps in 2024 due to abusive practices including contact-list shaming, illegal fees, and harassment. (Source: Business Elites Africa, July 2025.)
- Google updated its Play Store lending policy to require proof of regulatory approval and banned loan apps from accessing sensitive phone data after thousands of complaints. (Source: Angle360, February 2026.)

Example messages

Fake loan app promotion (SMS/WhatsApp)

Congratulations! You have been pre-approved for a ₦150,000 instant loan. No collateral. No guarantor. Disbursement in 5 minutes. Click: fastcash-ng.com. Offer expires in 2 hours.

Upfront fee scam

Your ₦200,000 loan has been approved. To process disbursement, pay a one-time insurance fee of ₦3,500 to this account: 0123456789 (GTBank — FastLoan Nigeria Ltd).

References

- Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Commission (FCCPC) enforcement actions, cited in Business Elites Africa, July 2025: businesselitesafrica.com/top-10-online-scams-nigerians-keep-falling-for-in-2025/
- Angle360, "Loan Sharks Exposed," February 2026: angle360ng.com/loan-sharks-exposed-list-of-fake-loan-apps-in-nigeria/

Cat 7

Fake Job Offer Scams

Documented by
Africa Check and
EFCC

Description

Fraudsters post attractive job listings on social media or send unsolicited job offers via WhatsApp and SMS. These offers promise high pay for little or no experience, often targeting the unemployed or recent graduates. Victims are asked to pay a registration or processing fee, provide personal documents that are used for identity theft, or recruit others in a multi-level marketing structure. Some scams impersonate legitimate companies or government agencies.

Documented evidence

- Unemployment remains a major issue in Nigeria. While job hunting, people often fall for fraudulent offers on social media that promise high pay for little to no experience or ask for upfront fees. (Source: Africa Check, February 2026.)

- Fraudulent companies post attractive job listings and request processing fees or personal documents from applicants, which are often identity theft traps. (Source: ThriveOnlineNigeria, October 2025.)

Example messages

Fake remote job (WhatsApp/SMS)

We are hiring remote data entry officers. Salary: ₦120,000 per month. No experience required. To secure your position, send your NIN, bank account details and a registration fee of ₦3,500 to 0987654321 (Access Bank — HR Dept).

Government agency impersonation

The Federal Ministry of Labour is recruiting community development officers nationwide. Apply now at fed-recruitment-ng.com. Registration fee: ₦2,000. Deadline: Friday.

References

- Africa Check, February 2026: africacheck.org/fact-checks/blog/guide-scam-trends-watch-out-2026-and-how-stay-safe-online
- ThriveOnlineNigeria, October 2025: thriveonlinenigeria.com/online-scams-in-nigeria-what-the-numbers-reveal-and-how-to-stay-safe

Cat 8

Government and Relief Fund Impersonation

Documented by
Africa Check
2024–26

Description

Scammers exploit economic hardship or real government announcements to circulate fake relief fund, grant, or palliative messages. Victims are directed to fraudulent websites or asked to provide BVN, NIN, or bank details to receive funds that do not exist. These scams frequently coincide with real government programmes, making them harder to dismiss. They arrive via SMS, WhatsApp broadcasts, and social media shares.

Documented evidence

- In March 2024, claims that the federal government was disbursing N30,000 in relief funds to all Nigerians began circulating online. Africa Check identified this as a scam. (Source: Africa Check, February 2026.)
- Scammers take advantage of economic hardship or news about government support programs to trick people into providing personal data or sending money. (Source: Africa Check, February 2026.)

Example messages

Federal government palliative scam (WhatsApp broadcast)

FG Palliative Alert: The Federal Government has approved ₦30,000 cash support for all Nigerian adults. Claim your funds before the deadline at fgpalliative-support.com. You will need your BVN and NIN to verify eligibility.

State government grant impersonation

Lagos State Residents Emergency Fund: You have been selected to receive ₦50,000 under the Lagos Economic Recovery Initiative. Visit lagosrelieffund.ng to register with your NIN within 48 hours.

References

- Africa Check, February 2026: africacheck.org/fact-checks/blog/guide-scam-trends-watch-out-2026-and-how-stay-safe-online
- AllAfrica, February 2026: allafrica.com/stories/202602200545.html

Category Summary

Cat	Category name	Primary channel	NIBSS/regulatory status
1	Phishing and fake bank alerts	SMS, WhatsApp	31% of attacks — NIBSS 2024
2	SIM swap fraud	Phone call, SMS	25% of attacks — NIBSS 2024
3	Identity theft and credential compromise	Data breach, SMS	21% of attacks — NIBSS 2024
4	Fake fintech and bank platform impersonation	WhatsApp, SMS, web	Documented — Africa Check 2025–26
5	Investment scams and Ponzi schemes	WhatsApp, Telegram, SMS	SEC Nigeria — N300.2bn losses
6	Fake loan app scams	SMS, app stores	FCCPC — 45+ apps delisted 2024
7	Fake job offer scams	WhatsApp, SMS, social media	EFCC documented
8	Government and relief fund impersonation	WhatsApp, SMS	Africa Check documented 2024–26